> Crowds of women surround him, and outside of this circle spearmen are ranged. The road is marked off with ropes, and it is death, for man and woman alike, to pass within the ropes. Men with drums and gongs lead the procession. The king hunts in the enclosures and shoots arrows from a platform. At his side stand two or three armed women. If he hunts in the open grounds he shoots from the back of an elephant. Of the women, some are in chariots, some on horses, and some even on elephants, and they are equipped with weapons of every kind, as if they were going on a campaign.[23]

In this matter the *Arthashastra* corroborates the *Indica*. It tells us of many women among the king's trusted helpers, from bow-bearing female guards when he rose in the morning to 'female slaves of proved integrity' who were supposed to 'do the work of bath-attendants, shampooers, bed-preparers, laundresses and garland-makers.'[24] In early sculptural representations too, as for instance at Bharhut in Central India, we find female attendants accompanying kings in procession. Ajatashatru is one of these kings and is shown sitting on his state elephant, with a woman attendant bearing the parasol behind him; the accompanying elephants are mounted by women mahouts.[25]

While all the anecdotes and allusions relating to the Mauryan royalty in the *Indica* contain no description of any of their residential quarters either, this may not have seemed a lack if the ruins of such establishments had survived. But nothing has remained. The archaeological evidence for a royal residence, and of the paraphernalia of streets and lanes and the secular and religious structures surrounding it, has been rendered insignificant by centuries of dust and over-building. Segments of structures and walls occasionally emerge in the course of modern construction, in localities such as Rajendranagar, where Mauryan terracottas were found when sewage lines were being laid; then in the Patna Dak bungalow area, which was demolished and replaced by a Kisan Bhawan, in the process exposing Mauryan pottery and numerous ring wells; and in the Patna Museum compound where Mauryan remains appeared in the course of digging for